



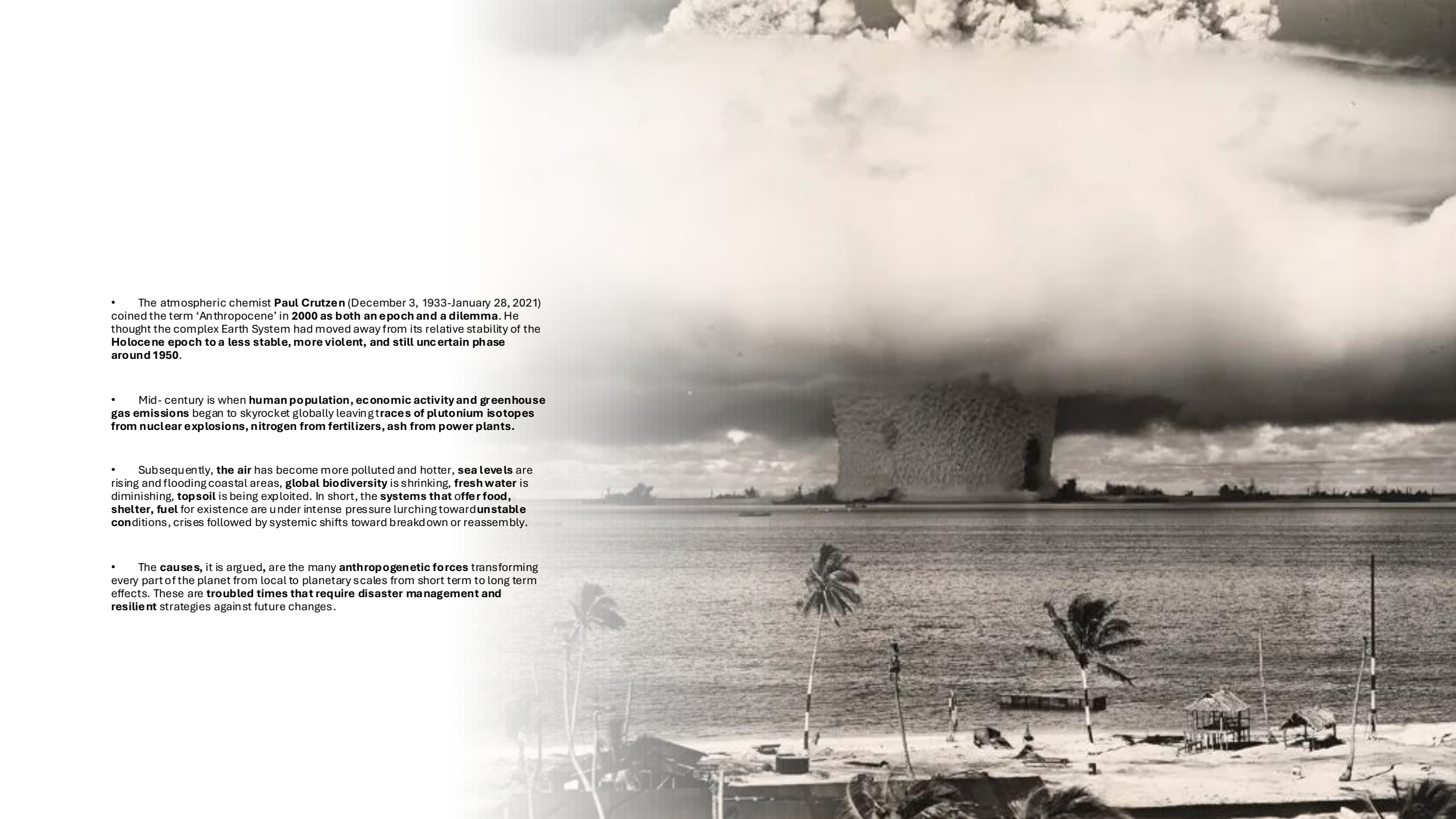
- **1WHAT IS THE ANTHROPOCENE ERA**

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- It is generally recognized that some fifty years ago, the Earth entered a new stage of existence due to **things humans had done to it and continue to still do**. This new geological era was named '**The Anthropocene**'. The naming, however, is not without controversy.

- Some object to the use of '**anthropos**' because it is a **universalizing** concept that overlooks the many inequalities of race, class, gender, caste, sexuality, and diverts attention away from the cause of our current environmental crisis being that of **capitalism's exploitative methods of extraction, constant search for profits, uneven accumulation of wealth**, to name a few difficulties.

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- Others object to the periodizing method that claims the Anthropocene era is **a post-1800 phenomenon** generated by the **industrial revolution followed by urbanization**, when they assume to the contrary that the date should be rolled back to at least **1492** and the beginning of European colonial expansion.
 - Still others take **stratigraphy and Earth System science** to be the touchstones from which to measure the physical dangers to the earth such as **warming events and loss of biodiversity**.
 - The trouble is the **geological timetable stretches back some 4.6 billion of years** divided by **eons, eras, periods, epochs and ages**. To label the modern period an epoch makes little sense to many geologists, archaeologists, and anthropologists who take a **longer view of global change**.



• The atmospheric chemist **Paul Crutzen** (December 3, 1933-January 28, 2021) coined the term 'Anthropocene' in **2000 as both an epoch and a dilemma**. He thought the complex Earth System had moved away from its relative stability of the **Holocene epoch to a less stable, more violent, and still uncertain phase around 1950**.

• Mid- century is when **human population, economic activity and greenhouse gas emissions** began to skyrocket globally leaving **traces of plutonium isotopes from nuclear explosions, nitrogen from fertilizers, ash from power plants**.

• Subsequently, **the air** has become more polluted and hotter, **sea levels** are rising and flooding coastal areas, **global biodiversity** is shrinking, **fresh water** is diminishing, **topsoil** is being exploited. In short, the **systems that offer food, shelter, fuel** for existence are under intense pressure lurching toward **unstable conditions**, crises followed by systemic shifts toward breakdown or reassembly.

• The **causes**, it is argued, are the many **anthropogenetic forces** transforming every part of the planet from local to planetary scales from short term to long term effects. These are **troubled times that require disaster management and resilient** strategies against future changes.

- **2/WHY DO CITIES MATTER in the ANTHROPOCENE ERA?**

- The Anthropocene era is usually associated with the planet's **rapid rate of urbanization** – some even refer to this conflation as the **urbicene**.
- Since **1950**, the world's population living in cities has doubled in size. It is projected by 2050, 68% of the Earth's population will live within cities. Much of this expansion has occurred in cities of the **Global South**. [The latter is a term for what were once referred to as The Developing Countries, The Third World countries, etc.]
- Land use changes resulting from urbanization have caused a **decline in biodiversity within their regions**. This requires cities to look beyond their regions for sustaining supplies of **food, energy, materials**. Cities are **giant machines sucking in energy and spewing out waste**.
- They generate as much as **three-quarters of human energy consumption and carbon emissions**. Their industries have polluted the **water, air and soil**.

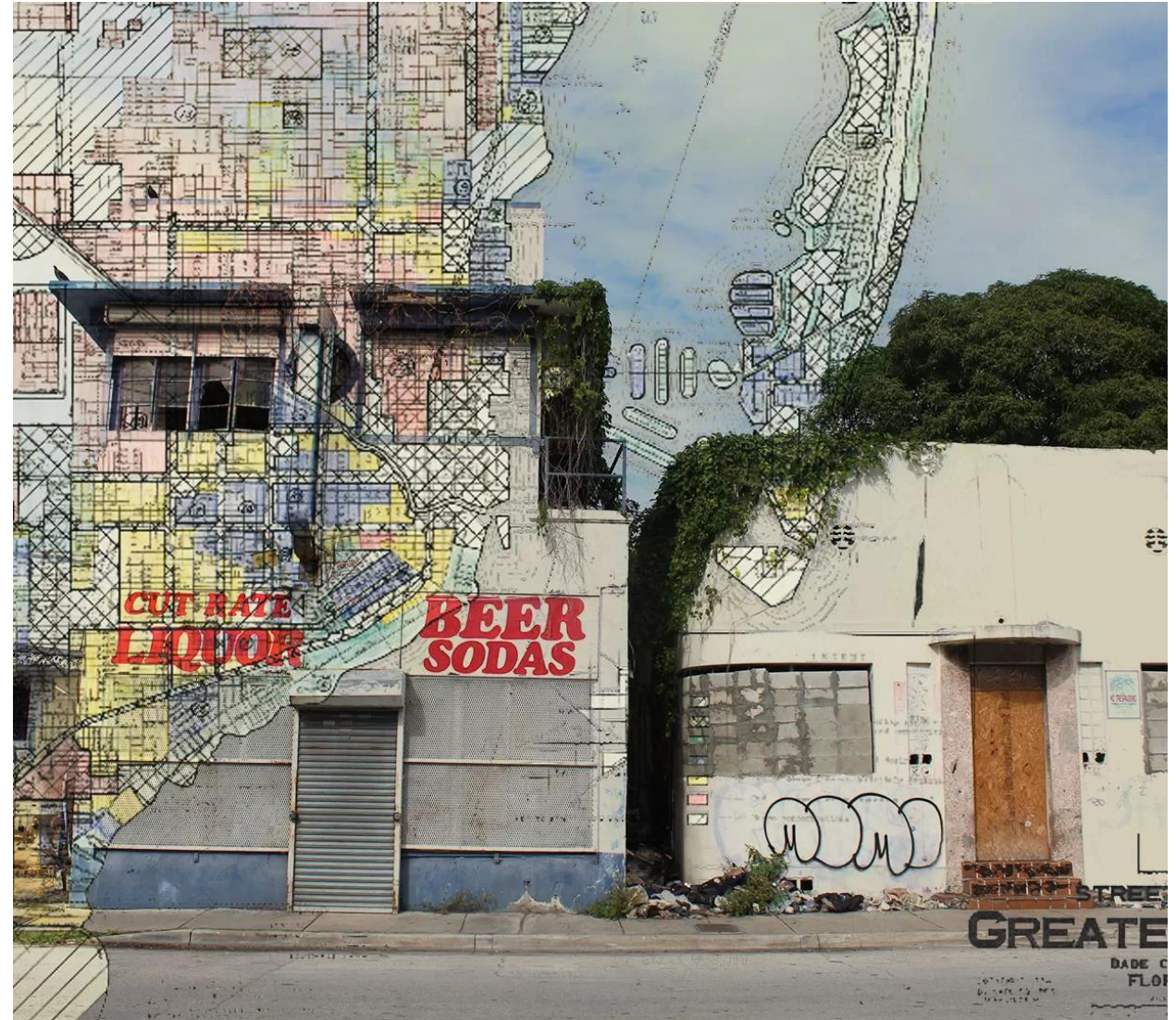


MIAMI MURALS from “Before it’s too Late”

- Many of the world's cities are in **coastal regions** prone to environmental disasters and hazards. They physically experience the dramatic **effects of hurricanes, severe flooding**, in addition to killer **heat waves, parching droughts, runaway wildfires, and pandemics** that other cities suffer as well.
- Cities are **vulnerable** to the ravages of the so-called Anthropocene epoch.
- The **UN believes that the battle for a sustainable Earth will be won or lost in cities**. Cities can become agents for transforming their relations with the environment. They are the **survival habitats of most of humanity** --- and it is in and through cities that environmental crises will **be managed, mitigated, transformed**.



- But will they be able to do so **inclusively, or equitably with resiliency for all**? Because **race matters** in the era of the Anthropocene.
- **Racism means** devaluing the humanity of certain people by dismissing or ignoring them.
- **Racism means** assuming that Western philosophy, ideas, concepts are **universal** – that they apply to all peoples – This a racist tactic based in Eurocentrism.
- The ‘**Anthropocene**’ is one of those **universalizing concepts**. It assumes the ‘**Anthropos**’ or man is responsible for changing the earth’s environment and **that ‘we are all in this together’** when not ‘all’ of us are responsible, not all of us share equally the devastations environmental disasters engendered.
- We need to **scrutinize the words we use, the problems we study, the perceptual frameworks we accept as natural** in order to undo the flow of ideas that follow a one-way street from the West to the East, from the North to the South.



Photographer: Hattie Mae Williams

3/WHY DOES RHETORIC MATTER WHEN SPEAKING ABOUT CIITIES?

Climate change may be a defining issue of our time—at least that is what the UN declares but **are we really living in an era of Anthropocene.?** What does that mean? And when did it start? Have we reached a ‘tipping point’?

Is the Anthropocene era defined by **an era of superstorms and wildfires, rising sea levels** and depleted water sources, heat waves and crop failures, climate migrations and decreased biodiversity?

Are we really in a life-or-death struggle for the Earth’s and therefore life’s survival?

Can we do anything about these global trends?

With a great deal of **uncertainty surrounding the rhetoric we need to be certain what these terms mean, what they render invisible**, why they intend to shock not to aid the development of alternatives.

I concerned about **the rhetoric surrounding the discussion of cities in the 21st Century**. And so, this course is organized around **the rhetoric of urban buzz words – which have become like names on a map of discovery. But what do they mean?**

We start out with “**Anthropocene**’ and the new buzzword ‘**Retreat**’ in the case study **Miami --- the number 1 city threatened by rising seas in the 21st century**.

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